SYSDESIGN REFERENCE

# Design a News Feed

Requirements-to-architecture reference walkthrough.

Rank and deliver personalized items under high fan-out and freshness pressure.

VERSION 1.0 REVIEW

REVIEWED THROUGH 2026-07-18

STATUS HUMAN REVIEW REQUIRED

SYSDESIGN / NEWS-FEED

SYSDESIGN

# Design a News Feed

**CORE IDEA**

**Rank and deliver personalized items under high fan-out and freshness pressure.**

## Reference architecture decision chain

| 01 | 02 | 03 | 04 |
|---|---|---|---|
| Fan-Out On Write Vs Read | Ranking | Candidate Stores | Celebrity Users |

### Decisions to defend

+ Fan-out on write vs read
+ ranking
+ candidate stores
+ celebrity users
+ and cache strategy.

### Failure modes to test

+ Hot publishers
+ stale ranking
+ deletion propagation
+ and fan-out backlog.

## Interview flow

- [ ] Clarify users, critical paths, and non-goals
- [ ] Estimate only scale that changes a decision
- [ ] Define API, data model, and source of truth
- [ ] Draw synchronous and asynchronous paths
- [ ] Pressure-test timeout, retry, overload, and recovery
- [ ] Close with tradeoffs and one alternative

Deep-dive drill

# Design a News Feed

| Probe | What a strong answer makes explicit |
| --- | --- |
| How does the design behave during a regional dependency failure? | Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric. |
| Which metric reveals the first bottleneck? | Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric. |
| What consistency does the user actually observe? | Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric. |
| How would the design change at ten times the traffic? | Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric. |

## Data questions

+ Partition key
+ Versioning
+ Uniqueness
+ Retention
+ Reconciliation

## Operations questions

+ SLO
+ Backlog
+ Capacity
+ Alert
+ Failover test

**DESIGN DISCIPLINE**

**For every box: which requirement justifies it, what cost does it introduce, and what happens when it fails?**

PUBLISHING STATUS

REVIEW GATE: TECHNICAL REVIEW. AI-produced draft. A named human must verify technical accuracy, sourcing, freshness, and editorial quality before publication. Reviewed-through date: 2026-07-18.